The prospect of major conflict with either China or Pakistan has declined with the introduction of nuclear weapons. Although India and Pakistan fought three large-scale conventional wars between 1947 and 1971, the only major conflict since their 1998 nuclear tests was an important but limited war in Kargil in 1999. Nuclear deterrence improves with a ‘triad’, the ability to deploy nuclear weapons by land (missiles), air (aircraft), and sea (submarines), something India has been developing since demonstrating its nuclear capability. [7] Nonetheless, conventional deterrence remains a necessity in localized or limited contingencies. As the ‘surgical strikes’ across the Line of Control have indicated, limited Pakistan-related contingencies might still be required to deter terrorism and counter military adventurism. India may enjoy a resource and technological advantage against Pakistan, but that should not lead to complacency.

With China, India faces a much more daunting challenge, as the border stand-offs of 2013, 2014, 2017, and 2020 made clear. China has recently undergone significant military reforms within the People’s Liberation Army (PLA), that have resulted in a smaller standing military force, upgraded equipment, and joint commands. [8] Its economic and technological edge, coupled with improved military infrastructure in Tibet and Xinjiang—including new or improved airfields, helicopter landing pads, missile silos, and road and rail infrastructure—means that the PLA poses a serious challenge to India on the border. Moreover, China’s aggressive intentions in the East China Sea, Taiwan Strait, and South China Sea, along with its growing presence in the Indian Ocean region, raise the prospect of a Chinese military challenge to India’s south, north, east, and west. [9]

Addressing the China challenge—in addition to a variety of other continencies on land, at sea, in the air, and in space—necessitates several significant changes in India’s defence structures, some of which are already underway. These include improvements to national security management and coordination; command, plans, and operational readiness; personnel (including recruitment and training); and procurement (including acquisitions and research and development). In all these areas, India faces a need to coordinate between the three military services, between the military